



MADRID SPAIN

Sweet Surrender in Madrid

Spain's traditional capital reveals its playful side in the early hours, when office-bound bankers cross paths with hungry clubbers in the *churrerías*. These small shops work around the clock crafting *churros* – deep-fried strips of dough that are Madrid's classic breakfast or afternoon snack and a powerful late-night restorative, especially when dipped in thick hot chocolate.



From its formal old-world plazas and medieval lanes to its modernist offices and galleries, Madrid comes alive each day to the smell of *churros*. This essential breakfast fuels office workers and laborers alike, and it also provides a morning jump-start for museum-goers making their pilgrimages to the treasure houses on the city's Golden Triangle of art: the eclectic Museo Thyssen-Bornamisza, the legendary Museo del Prado with its works by Goya and Velázquez (see also pp136–7), and the thought-provoking, sometimes controversial Museo Nacional Centro de Arte Reina Sofía, Spain's national museum of 20th- and 21st-century art.

By mid-afternoon, there are shopping bags at every table in the *churrerías*, as intrepid boutique warriors pause for the *merienda*, or afternoon snack, whether in the cluster of designer shops and custom cobblers of the Salamanca neighborhood or along the bustling streets in the vibrant barrio of Chueca. *Churros* are often hard to find after dark in other Spanish cities,

but not in Madrid, where the tasty fritters imbue *Madriños* with the stamina to keep going until they drop. When the flamenco show ends at 1:00 AM or the sky shows dawn's early streaks as the dance clubs close, the *churrerías* beckon.

Thought to have been created as an easy breakfast for mountain shepherds (*churra* is an ancient breed of Iberian sheep), *churros* are among the simplest of sweets – a basic batter of flour, salt, and water piped into bubbling vats of oil. Fried into finger-sized sticks that are soft on the inside but brown and crisp on the outside, they must be eaten before they cool – ideally dusted with sugar and dipped into coffee or a cup of mud-thick Spanish hot chocolate – for an explosion of warmth that radiates from mouth to fingertips.

So central is the shepherd's breakfast to *Madriños* that no festival in the city is complete without *churro* carts. As the street music rises to a proper Spanish din, vendors fire up their gas heaters to bring their oil to a bubbling sizzle, squirt in the dough, and transform a simple batter into a sweet celebratory treat.

A Day in Madrid

Madrid remains as vibrant at night as during the day. The monumental fountains of Neptuno and Cibeles along the Paseo del Prado are most dramatic when illuminated. The complex rhythms and mournful song of flamenco only begin after dinner (that is, midnight), and the trance beat of the dance clubs starts throbbing in the *madrugada*, or early morning.

MORNING Picasso's masterpiece, *Guernica*, is reason enough to visit the **Museo Nacional Centro de Arte Reina Sofía**, but don't miss the extensive collection of paintings and sculptures by Madrid-born Juan Gris and the ever-cryptic and mercurial Joan Miró.

AFTERNOON Seek out fashions by many of Spain's young, avant-garde designers in the trendy **Chueca** neighborhood, also known for its gay-friendly nightlife. For the best in Spanish footwear at bargain prices, peruse the shops on **Calle Augusto Figueroa**.

EVENING Begin with drinks in the upmarket culinary center of **Mercado San Miguel**. Eat dinner and watch Madrid's best flamenco at **Casa Patas**. After the show, dance until dawn at **Disco-Teatro Joy Eslava** and end the evening's revelries with *churros* and chocolate.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Madrid lies near the geographical center of Spain. Most international airlines fly into **Madrid-Barajas Airport**, 7 miles (12 km) from downtown Madrid. The best way to get around the city is by **metro**.

WHERE TO STAY

Hotel Plaza Mayor (inexpensive) is a welcoming option in a 200-year-old church building. www.h-plazamayor.com
Room Mate Oscar Hotel (moderate) is a playful designer hotel in hip Chueca. www.room-matehotels.com

Catalonia Las Cortes (moderate) offers rooms in a converted 18th-century palace. www.hoteles-catalonia.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Plaza Mayor 27; www.esmadrid.com

